

Ragam X The Literary and Debating Club
Presents

SAHITI

Equity Policy

Asian Parliamentary Debate



EQUITY POLICY

1. Preamble

Debate competitions are spaces designed to promote the free exchange of ideas, critical thinking, and respectful engagement. While debates often involve strong disagreements and controversial topics, all participants must engage in a manner that respects the dignity, identity, and wellbeing of others.

This Equity Policy exists to ensure that the tournament remains a safe, inclusive, and respectful environment, free from harassment, discrimination, intimidation, and other forms of harmful conduct. The policy outlines standards of behaviour, reporting procedures, and enforcement mechanisms applicable to all participants.

Participation in the tournament constitutes agreement to abide by this policy.





2. Purpose and Objectives

The objectives of this Equity Policy are to:

1. Ensure that all participants have equal opportunity to participate in the debate competition.
2. Foster an environment free from harassment, discrimination, and intimidation.
3. Protect participants' mental, emotional, and physical wellbeing.
4. Establish a clear mechanism for addressing equity concerns.
5. Encourage respectful discourse even when debating controversial issues.

Equity policies in debate tournaments are intended to guarantee that everyone can participate fully regardless of identity, background, or personal characteristics.





3. Scope of Application

This policy applies to all individuals associated with the tournament, including but not limited to:

- Debaters
 - Adjudicators and adjudication core
 - Organising committee members
 - Tabulation team
 - Coaches and team managers
 - Observers
 - Volunteers and staff
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The policy applies to:

- Debate rounds
- Preparation time
- Feedback sessions
- Tournament communications
- Social events connected to the tournament
- Online communication platforms used by the tournament

Equity policies typically apply for the entire duration of the competition and across all official platforms used by the event.



4. Equity Team

The tournament shall appoint an Equity Committee consisting of designated Equity Officers.

Responsibilities of the Equity Team

The Equity Team shall:

- Receive and handle complaints regarding equity violations
- Maintain confidentiality where appropriate
- Provide mediation between parties where possible
- Recommend disciplinary action where necessary
- Ensure participants feel safe raising concerns

Equity officers act as the primary contact for individuals experiencing discrimination or misconduct.



5. Code of Conduct

All participants must behave respectfully and professionally at all times.

Participants must:

- Treat all individuals with dignity and respect
- Respect pronouns, names, and personal identities
- Avoid discriminatory or offensive remarks
- Follow instructions of tournament officials
- Accept adjudication decisions respectfully
- Provide constructive feedback without hostility

Participants must not engage in behaviour that disrupts debates or undermines the fairness of the competition.





6. Prohibited Conduct

The following behaviours are strictly prohibited.

6.1 Discrimination

Discrimination against any individual or group based on protected characteristics including:

- Race or ethnicity
- Religion
- Nationality
- Gender
- Sexual orientation
- Gender identity
- Disability
- Age
- Socioeconomic background

Participants must avoid harmful stereotypes or generalisations during debates or interactions.





6.2 Harassment

Harassment includes any unwanted behaviour that intimidates, humiliates, or creates a hostile environment.

Examples include:

- Offensive jokes or remarks
- Repeated insults
- Threatening behaviour
- Unwelcome comments about personal identity

Harassment based on protected attributes is not tolerated in debate spaces.



6.3 Sexual Harassment

Sexual harassment includes:

- Unwanted physical contact
- Sexual comments or jokes
- Requests for sexual favours
- Sending unsolicited explicit messages
- Persistent romantic advances after rejection

Romantic relationships between participants and officials (e.g., judges or organisers) during the competition may also raise equity concerns.



6.4 Bullying

Bullying refers to repeated behaviour that intimidates, degrades, or undermines another participant.

Examples include:

- Public humiliation
- Persistent hostile behaviour
- Pressuring individuals into uncomfortable actions

Bullying is prohibited in all tournament spaces.



6.5 Hate Speech

Hate speech includes:

- Language that incites violence or discrimination
- Dehumanising statements about groups
- Derogatory slurs

Arguments about political systems or policies must be framed carefully without attacking individuals or communities

6.6 Inappropriate Behaviour During Debates

During rounds participants must not:

- Heckle speakers excessively
- Interrupt speeches
- Use mocking gestures or expressions
- Engage in aggressive confrontations after adjudication

Participants are expected to interact respectfully with adjudicators and other teams.



7. Conduct During Debates

Debaters must remember that debates are about arguments, not individuals. Acceptable debate practices include:

- Challenging ideas
- Critiquing policies
- Engaging in strong argumentative discourse

However, arguments must not target individuals personally or demean communities. Judges should evaluate debates on argumentative merit and should not independently enforce equity penalties during rounds; instead, violations should be reported to the equity team.



8. Reporting Equity Violations

Participants may report violations through:

- Direct contact with an Equity Officer
- Written complaint form
- Anonymous reporting channels (if available)
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Reports may be submitted by:

- Victims
- Witnesses
- Tournament officials

All complaints will be handled confidentially to the extent possible.

9. Investigation Procedure

Upon receiving a complaint, the Equity Team may:

3. Speak with the complainant
4. Speak with the accused participant
5. Consult witnesses
6. Review available evidence
7. Conduct mediation where appropriate

The Equity Team may consult the Adjudication Core or Tournament Director if required.



10. Possible Outcomes

Depending on the severity of the violation, actions may include:

- Informal mediation
- Verbal warning
- Written warning
- Speaker point penalties
- Disqualification from rounds
- Removal from the tournament
- Reporting to institutional authorities

Minor issues may be resolved through discussion, while serious violations may result in expulsion from the competition.





11. Final Authority

The final decision regarding equity violations rests with the Equity Committee in consultation with the Tournament Director and Adjudication Core. Their decisions are binding for the purposes of the tournament.

12. Acknowledgement

All participants are deemed to have accepted this Equity Policy upon registering for the tournament.

By participating in the competition, individuals agree to uphold the principles of respect, fairness, and inclusivity.

